EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 13 OCTOBER 2026

Northfield, Aberdeen

Aberdeen's winter deaths are mostly very old people dying of flu, RSV, and cold homes. They happen every year, El Niño or not, and this year's flu season has started earlier than any on record. The deaths cluster among the very old, not in particular postcodes. So the most lives are saved by vaccinating care-home staff and mopping up RSV vaccination for the over-80s, by getting pensioners' Pension Credit claims in before 23 November, and by signing older residents onto SSEN's Priority Services Register before the first storm.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
Aberdeen City council area, about 227,000 people (inferred)	None published for the UK or Scotland	n/a here; global 6-month figure 239,000 ± 11,000 (heat only)	Flu, RSV, and cold homes among the very old; storms and multi-day power cuts; ice

16/16 recommendations checked. 1 confirmed as written (flu vaccination for care-home staff), 11 corrected, 2 unverified (a council cold-snap payment and a vaccination pop-up at Northfield), and 2 contraindicated (storm packs and a separate cash-first pilot, both of which duplicate money already committed). The five funding placements were checked separately: 1 partially confirmed, 2 unverified, and 2 contraindicated. **The funding target fell 54%**, from £65k to £30k. That is more than the one-third flag, because Aberdeen City Council and SSEN already fund most of what the lens proposed. What remains is an adviser and targeted fuel credit. Exposure: Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk, September 2026, pre-peer-review. It publishes no figure for the UK, and heat is not

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



57.17°N 2.16°W, United Kingdom · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** Flu, RSV, and cold homes among the very old cause most winter deaths here, every year, and this year's flu season has started earlier than any on record.
- **First action.** NHS Grampian and the Aberdeen City HSCP vaccinate care-home staff against flu now, and finish RSV vaccination for everyone 80 and over and all care-home residents before December.*
- **The money.** £15k floor, £30k target, £60k ceiling; most proposals were already paid for, including a £50k cash-first pilot, £95k for fuel poverty, and £125k of SSEN battery packs.
- **Do not.** Do not tell people it will be a mild El Niño winter: the Met Office also warns of "colder and calmer late winter periods."

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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

this place's winter hazard. Local mortality figures are for Aberdeen City (National Records of Scotland), not Northfield.

Where this is. The request named “Northfield, Aberdeenshire”. The only places called Northfield in Aberdeenshire council area are farm steadings. The Northfield people mean is the Aberdeen City suburb in postcode district AB16, part of the Northfield/Mastrick North ward. Aberdeen City and Aberdeenshire are separate councils, so this briefing names Aberdeen City Council throughout. It covers Northfield together with the neighbouring Mastrick, Cummings Park, Heathryfold, and Middlefield, which the council treats as one group of priority neighbourhoods.

Read this first: El Niño is a weak guide here. The Met Office (11 June 2026) says El Niño “can increase the likelihood of … milder, wetter and windier weather during autumn and early winter” and “can also be associated with colder and calmer late winter periods in the UK.” Aberdeen's deadliest recent winters were not El Niño winters. 2017–18, with 249 excess deaths in Aberdeen City, was a La Niña flu season with the Beast from the East. Storm Arwen in 2021 was also a La Niña. In the last El Niño, Storm Babet came in October 2023 and shut the A90. So the plan is a standing winter plan that runs to April. A “mild El Niño winter” message would tell people to relax just before the most likely cold, in February and March.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO

RANKED

Actions are ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak. The backing lenses are shown on each action, and the RACI chart below assigns each one. An action several lenses reached independently is the stronger bet, but only where its evidence came from somewhere like here. One rule runs through all of them: in Aberdeen in 2024/25, excess winter deaths among people 85 and over ran at 39% above the

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

non-winter level, and Scotland's winter deaths show no consistent deprivation gradient. So target by age and frailty first, and by postcode second.

1. Vaccinate care-home staff against flu now, and mop up RSV vaccination for every unvaccinated person 80 and over and every care-home resident *

CONFIRMED (STAFF FLU) PARTIALLY CONFIRMED (RSV) PUBLIC HEALTH · EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN · PHILANTHROPIST

INVENTORY: COULD NOT BE CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
NHS Grampian and Aberdeen City Health and Social Care Partnership (HSCP); care-home operators for staff	**Staff flu now; RSV mop-up before December**	**Existing programmes**	**Flu and RSV deaths among the very old, where most winter deaths fall**

Public Health Scotland's report of 8 October 2026 says influenza was “higher in week 40 than all previous reported seasons,” with people over 65 making up over half of flu admissions, although overall activity is still at baseline. Vaccinating care-home staff is the best-evidenced action here. In a cluster trial, resident deaths fell by 5.0 per 100 residents (95% CI 2.0–7.0) in a season when flu was circulating (Hayward, *BMJ* 2006). A Cochrane review found a risk ratio of 0.69 for residents' all-cause deaths (2025; moderate certainty). The room for gain is large: flu uptake among Scotland's social-care staff was 18.4% in 2024/25 and an interim 13.6% for 2025/26. Scotland's RSV expansion to everyone 80 and over and to older-adult care-home residents began in spring 2026. Care homes were due to finish by 30 June, and everyone else had to be offered an appointment by 30 September. So in Northfield this is a mop-up of people who were missed or declined.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: Scottish and UK evidence. The 62.1% fall in RSV admissions came from the first-year analysis of 75–79-year-olds, so applying it to people over 80 is an extrapolation. Correction made in verification: the expansion started in spring 2026, not in September. Flu vaccination for people aged 65–74 has weaker evidence (Anderson, Dobkin & Gorry 2020). Unverified: no NHS Grampian clinic at Northfield was found. The city hub at the Bon Accord Centre does drop-ins Monday to Saturday (01224 555333).

2. Get pensioners' Pension Credit claims in by 23 November, through Citizens Advice's sessions at Northfield and Mastrick community centres

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST | INVENTORY: COULD NOT BE CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Citizens Advice Aberdeen (Northfield Thursdays, Mastrick Tuesdays); Aberdeen City Council Financial Inclusion Team	**23 Nov for the Warm Home Discount; 20 Dec for the winter heating payment**	**£15k if the outreach post is unfunded (see funding)**	**Pensioners missing statutory money that one claim unlocks**

Pension Credit can be backdated three months. This winter's Warm Home Discount (£150) has a qualifying date of 23 August 2026, so a claim has to be in by about 23 November to reach back to it. The Pension Age Winter Heating Payment's qualifying week is 21–27 September, so the deadline for that is about 20 December. The payment's rates run from £105.55 to £316.70, depending on age and household. Pension Credit lifts it for some households, chiefly people in shared households, from £105.55 to £211.15. Anyone with income over £35k can opt out until **midday on 19 October**. Citizens Advice Aberdeen gained an average of £869 per client in 2024–25 (£5.07m for 5,837 clients).

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: native. Corrections made in verification: “Pension Credit unlocks the top rate” overstates it, because the £316.70 rate depends on age (80+), and a couple gains about nothing. The lens's 20 December deadline was too late for the Warm Home Discount. The lens's rates were last year's. The £1,059 mean gain was 2023–24. Ofgem lists all Pension Credit recipients in Scotland, not only Guarantee Credit, as automatic for the discount; check against the 2026 DESNZ statement.

3. Sign older and vulnerable residents onto SSEN's Priority Services Register at the door, and feed the results into the council's Persons at Risk Database

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · FRONTLINE · HISTORIAN · ECONOMIST · PUBLIC HEALTH | INVENTORY: COULD NOT BE CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Aberdeen City Council Resilience, which holds the Persons at Risk Database (PARD), with the HSCP; volunteers at Cummings Park Community Flat and Northfield Community Centre do the sign-ups	**30 Nov**	**Volunteer and staff time; the register is free**	**Older and device-dependent people unchecked on day three of a power cut**

The Storm Arwen reviews found that the core failure was not knowing who was vulnerable. About 40,000 customers were off supply for more than three days and nearly 4,000 for more than a week, and 28% were given restoration times that were wrong by more than a day (Ofgem; 20 recommendations, plus 15 from the Scottish Government). After Arwen, Aberdeen's City Resilience Group made a city Persons at Risk Database a priority, and an upgrade was due before winter 2025. SSEN's register is free and needs no proof. It covers people over 60 (one SSEN notice says pensionable age), disabled people, people who rely on medical equipment, households with children under 5, and people with chronic illness. It brings warnings before storms, welfare support during them, and battery packs for some. The Emergency manager's point: people die on days three to five, after the phones and care rotas have failed. Print the list.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: native precedent. Corrections made in verification: build on the existing database rather than a new street list. Volunteers should do sign-ups only and not hold health data. Whether the database upgrade finished could not be confirmed. Storm compensation from SSEN (£90 after 48 hours in a major storm, plus £45 per extra 6 hours, up to £2,235) is automatic and does not depend on the register.

4. Target heating money at fuel-poor people over 75 or with heart disease, through SCARF's fuel fund, not at every household in the area

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST · ECONOMIST | INVENTORY: COULD NOT BE CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
SCARF (Scarf Fuel Fund, up to £294 per household, 2026 round open); GP practices and the HSCP as referrers	**Referrals from November**	**£15–30k top-up, conditional (see funding)**	**Cold-home deaths among the oldest and sickest**

About 17% of cold-related deaths in people over 75 in England were attributable to fuel poverty (Wan et al., *JECH* 2026). Insulation cut deaths in people with prior circulatory illness (hazard ratio 0.67; Preval, *BMJ Open* 2017, New Zealand). Untargeted winter cash has weak and mixed evidence: one biomarker improved, and nothing else robustly did. The value of each pound therefore depends on targeting by age and illness. Aberdeen's fuel poverty is 26% overall and 36% among social tenants. The council's 2026/27 cost-of-living budget (£1.019m) already includes £95k for fuel poverty, and SCARF received about £130k of council fuel-voucher money in 2024–25. Any top-up should go only where that runs out.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: English and New Zealand evidence, extrapolated. The respiratory result in Preval was not significant, so heart disease has better support than lung disease. Correction made in verification: the NHS-referred Warm Home Prescription pilot in Aberdeen (2022–24) was paid for by Energy Systems Catapult and bp. No live referral route for 2026–27 was found, so this uses SCARF's own fund.

5. Check Granitehill House and Mastrick Land before winter: heating type, backup boilers, lift standby power, and a list of residents who cannot use the stairs

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN · SKEPTIC | INVENTORY: COULD NOT BE CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Aberdeen City Council Housing, with Aberdeen Heat & Power	15 Nov	Existing maintenance budget	Residents stranded in cold flats when the lifts or heating fail

Northfield's tower is Granitehill House, 10 storeys on Marchburn Drive. Its heating could not be confirmed. Mastrick Land, 14 storeys with 52 flats, is on Aberdeen Heat & Power's communal gas heating. In 2001 the council found about 70% of residents in its multi-storey blocks in fuel poverty, and it set up Aberdeen Heat & Power in response. The action: confirm each block's heating, test backup boilers and lift standby power, insulate exposed boiler condensate pipes (the cause of many council boiler failures in the December 2010 freeze in Birmingham), and list residents who could not use the stairs in an outage so that they can be moved before a forecast storm.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: native. Correction made in verification: the lens's premise that the Northfield blocks are on district heating was wrong. Aberdeen Heat & Power's combined heat and power clusters are at Stockethill and Cairncry, Hazlehead, Seaton, and Tillydrone, and the company served just under 3,000 flats in 33 blocks in 2013, not 2,350.

6. Put CO alarms in all-electric and storage-heater flats, check the alarms in gas-heated homes, and tell everyone: no barbecue, camping stove, or generator indoors *

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | SKEPTIC · EMERGENCY MGR | INVENTORY: COULD NOT BE CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Aberdeen City Council Housing; Scottish Fire and Rescue Service for the highest-risk homes	1 Dec	Small; *unfunded*	CO poisoning from improvised heating and cooking in power cuts

Since February 2022, Scotland's Tolerable Standard requires a CO alarm in any room with a carbon-fuelled appliance or flue. That means council tenants with gas boilers should already be covered, and the job there is to check that the alarms work. The uncovered homes are all-electric and storage-heater flats. Nothing in them requires an alarm, and they are where people improvise in a power cut. During Storm Eunice in 2022, a resident in Devon used a gas barbecue indoors, and a CO alarm got everyone out. Scottish Fire and Rescue Service home visits now go only to the highest-risk homes, through a screening questionnaire (0800 0731 999).

Transferability: the case is from England. Not verified: whether Aberdeen City Council fitted CO alarms across its stock. About 2,500 homes were still without the new smoke alarms in March 2022 because tenants refused access.

7. Grit the paths to the blocks, sheltered housing, and community centres first when ice is forecast

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | HISTORIAN | INVENTORY: COULD NOT BE CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Aberdeen City Council Roads and Housing	Priority routes agreed by 1 Dec	Existing gritting budget	Falls and head injuries among older people

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

On 19 January 2023, NHS Grampian's emergency departments saw 84 falls in one day against 16 the week before, and about 35% were head injuries. Falls nearly doubled again after snow in November 2025. The Met Office says late winter in an El Niño year can be colder, so keep the priority routes in force through March.

Transferability: native. Correction made in verification: the 425% rise was in one day, not one week.

8. Confirm this winter's warm-space hours at Northfield Community Centre and Cummings Park Community Flat, and add days during cold snaps and power cuts

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · FRONTLINE · EMERGENCY MGR · INVENTORY: COULD NOT BE CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Aberdeen City Council community learning, with Cummings Park Community Flat's volunteers	31 Oct	Volunteer time	Nowhere warm to go during the day in a cold snap

Cummings Park Community Flat (122 Cummings Park Drive) is open roughly 1–4:30pm Monday to Thursday, depending on volunteers, and usually has a room free to sit and warm up. An undated council listing has Northfield Community Centre (Byron Square, 01224 695416) open as a warm space on Mondays only. The council's warm-space pages now return errors, so confirm the 2026–27 list. Use these rooms as the place where people sign up for actions 2 and 3, because the people most at risk come to the pantry queue, not to a council web page.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: native. Warm spaces have only qualitative evidence, so do not count visits as success. No generator was found at either venue, so they cannot be relied on as warm rooms during a power cut.

9. Cash first through the council's own pilot and the Scottish Welfare Fund, and a small ambient and no-cook food stock at Mastrick and Northfield community centres before the A90 next closes

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FOOD · SKEPTIC · ECONOMIST | INVENTORY: COULD NOT BE CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Aberdeen City Council Financial Inclusion Team; CFINE (which runs FareShare in the region) with council resilience	**Stock by 30 Nov; cash throughout**	**Cash: already funded (£50k council pilot). Stock: unverified, *unfunded***	**Heat-or-eat choices; empty shelves when the A90 closes**

Aberdeen is at the end of one trunk road. During Storm Babet in October 2023, the A90 shut at the Brechin bypass and Aberdeen shelves emptied for days. In the 2018 Beast from the East, the produce aisles at Tesco Lang Stracht were “mostly empty.” CFINE gave out 54,398 parcels in 2025, against 35,307 in 2022. Emergency food runs at Mastrick Community Centre on Tuesdays 9–3 and at Northfield on Tuesday evenings and Thursdays 10–2, and the mobile pantry stops on alternate Tuesdays. The price shock will come later: food inflation is forecast to peak at 6.4% in July 2027 (FDF), after every winter scheme ends. Scotland's Cash-First evaluation (29 September 2026), with Aberdeen as a partner, found mixed results, but cash remains the default. Families should claim Scottish Child Payment and Best Start Foods. Free school meals in P6 are for families getting Scottish Child Payment.

Transferability: native. Corrections made in verification: CFINE's FareShare warehouse has a waiting list because supply is short, so stock may need buying in. A price trigger on monthly ONS food inflation would not fire before stock is needed. Forward-buying should be small and tied to storage, because it pulls money away from cash. The parcel figures come from CFINE's own site, not Trussell.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	NHS Grampian & HSCP	Care-home operators	Citizens Advice Aberdeen	ACC Financial Inclusion	ACC Housing	ACC Resilience	ACC Roads	SSEN	SCARF	CFINE	Community centres & volunteers	Aberdeen Heat & Power	Scottish Fire & Rescue
1. Care-home staff flu; RSV mop-up 80+	**A/R**	**R**									**I**		
2. Pension Credit claims by 23 Nov			**A/R**	**R**	**I**				**C**	**I**	**R**		
3. Priority Services Register; PARD	**R**				**R**	**A**		**R**	**C**		**R**		**I**
4. Targeted heating money	**R**		**C**	**C**					**A/R**		**I**		
5. Tower checks: heat, lifts, stairs list	**C**				**A/R**	**C**		**I**			**I**	**R**	
6. CO alarms; “never indoors”					**A/R**	**C**		**C**	**I**		**R**		**R**
7. Priority gritting	**I**				**C**	**C**	**A/R**				**I**		
8. Warm-space hours			**I**	**C**		**C**				**I**	**A/R**		
9. Cash first; small food stock			**C**	**A/R**		**C**				**R**	**R**		

What the chart shows. **Aberdeen City Council is accountable for five of the nine rows**, across four departments, and most of those need a decision or a check rather than money. **NHS Grampian carries the row with the most lives in it. The community centres and their volunteers are responsible on six rows**, because they are where the people most at risk actually turn up. Their capacity is the main delivery risk.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Placements are ranked by marginal lives saved per pound. The envelope is bounded by what this place can spend before the peak, not by what it needs. Most of the lens's proposals were already paid for: the council has a £50k cash-first pilot and £95k for fuel poverty in its 2026/27 budget, and SSEN has funded £125k of battery packs.

FLOOR	TARGET	CEILING	LARGEST UNCERTAINTY
£15k	£30k	£60k	Whether Citizens Advice's outreach post is funded for 2026/27, and whether a clinical referral route to fuel credit exists

Floor: £15k for the Citizens Advice adviser, once it is confirmed in writing that the post is unfunded. **Target:** £15k adviser + £15k SCARF fuel-fund top-up = **£30k**. **Ceiling:** £15k + £30k SCARF + a £10k top-up to the council's existing cash-first pilot + £5k for a vaccination session at

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Northfield, if NHS Grampian will run one = **£60k**. The basis for the adviser: 0.6 FTE for about six months, about 120 clients, at Citizens Advice Aberdeen's 2024–25 mean gain of £869 (£5,069,233 ÷ 5,837 clients, shown as a division) is about £104k of statutory money unlocked. **The target fell 54%** from the lens's £65k. The separate cash-first pilot and storm packs duplicated money already committed, and the clinic and fuel-credit lines could not be confirmed.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
Citizens Advice Aberdeen	Action 2: 0.6 FTE Pension Credit adviser at Northfield and Mastrick to March	£15k, conditional	Direct grant	Mean client gain of £869 in 2024–25. The outreach posts were Fairer Aberdeen Fund money, “subject to continued funding” after March 2025; the fund was kept at £1.54m for 2026/27. Fund only if the post is unfunded.	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
SCARF (Scarf Fuel Fund)	Action 4: fuel credit for over-75s and people with heart disease in fuel poverty, after the council's £95k runs out	£15k target; £30k ceiling	Top-up to an existing fund	Up to £294 per household, so about 50–100 households. Wan 2026 for direction. The lens's cost per QALY (Chalabi 2015) costs the whole Cold Weather Plan, not fuel credit, so it is not used.	UNVERIFIED
Aberdeen City Council cash-first pilot	Action 9: top-up only	£0 target; £10k ceiling	Top-up	The council already funds a £50k pilot and £60k of crisis grants. A separate pilot would duplicate it.	CONTRAINDICATED AS STANDALONE
Northfield Community Centre	Action 1: a vaccination session, with transport	£0 target; £5k ceiling	Direct grant	No NHS Grampian clinic at Northfield and no evidence that transport is the barrier. The Bon Accord Centre hub does drop-ins.	UNVERIFIED
CFINE	Storm packs (blankets, power banks, flasks)	£0	Dropped	The council already gives out SSEN-funded battery packs (£125k). No evidence of need; the Cupar briefing dropped power-cut kits for the same reason.	CONTRAINDICATED

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The funder's one thing: the cheapest life-saving pound here pays for a claim form, not fuel. The state already owes pensioners money that one claim unlocks, and a pound spent on the adviser recovers several times its value in statutory support. Pay for the adviser before paying for any fuel.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives, or waste the window, here.

Tell people it will be a mild El Niño winter

AVOID (SKEPTIC; MET OFFICE, 11 JUNE 2026)

The Met Office says El Niño can bring a milder, wetter, and windier early winter here, and also “colder and calmer late winter periods.” Aberdeen's worst recent winters for deaths were not El Niño winters. A “mild winter” message relaxes people just before the most likely cold.

Instead: run a standing winter plan, triggered by Met Office warnings, through to April.

Hand out “heat one room and turn the heating down” leaflets in damp flats *

AVOID (SKEPTIC; UKHSA GUIDANCE)

Under-heating makes condensation, damp, and mould worse, and mould harms the lungs of the old and the very young. Scotland's version of Awaab's Law came into force on 6 October 2026. Social landlords must now investigate damp within 10 working days and complete repairs within 20.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: report damp to the landlord under the new duty, and put heating money and benefit claims (actions 2 and 4) in place so that tenants can heat the whole flat.

Spend winter money by postcode alone

`AVOID (PUBLIC HEALTH; NRS 2024/25)`

National Records of Scotland finds “no clear evidence of any consistent difference” in winter excess deaths by deprivation. In 2024/25 the increase was 14% in the most deprived areas and 18% in the second-least deprived. Northfield's high death rates are a year-round, premature-death problem. Its winter deaths will be very old people dying of flu, RSV, and cold.

Instead: target by age and frailty (actions 1, 3, and 4), and use Northfield's community rooms as the place to find those people.

Fund new storm packs, or a second cash-first pilot

`CONTRAINDICATED: DUPLICATES COMMITTED MONEY`

The council already gives out SSEN-funded battery packs (£125k) and runs a £50k cash-first pilot with £60k of crisis grants. Parallel schemes split the same small pool of staff and volunteers.

Instead: top up the existing pilot if it runs out (funding ceiling), and leave storm kit to the council and SSEN.

Let volunteers keep paper lists of people's health conditions

`AVOID (VERIFICATION FINDING)`

A stairwell list of who is on oxygen is health data, and the council already holds a Persons at Risk Database built after Arwen. A second, informal register is a data-protection risk.

Instead: volunteers sign people up to the Priority Services Register, and the council and HSCP do the matching (action 3). A stair captain needs only to know who to knock for.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

DATE	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
2001–02	Council finds about 70% of multi-storey tenants in fuel poverty on electric heating	n/a	Aberdeen Heat & Power founded; just under 3,000 flats in 33 blocks by 2013
Dec 2010	Deep freeze in a La Niña winter (ONI −1.3)	Not found for Aberdeen	n/a
2017–18	Severe flu season plus the Beast from the East; La Niña (−0.7); empty produce aisles at Tesco Lang Stracht	249 excess winter deaths in Aberdeen City (IWMI 37%)	n/a
26–27 Nov 2021	Storm Arwen; La Niña; ~40,000 customers off >3 days and nearly 4,000 >1 week	One driver killed in Aberdeenshire; no outage deaths found	Ofgem's 20 and the Scottish Government's 15 recommendations; ~£44m paid including redress; city Persons at Risk Database
19 Jan 2023	Ice	84 falls at Grampian emergency departments in one day, about 35% head injuries	n/a
18–21 Oct 2023	Storm Babet during a strong El Niño (+1.9); A90 shut at Brechin; Aberdeen shelves emptied; Peterculter evacuated	Deaths in Angus and Aberdeenshire, none in the city	n/a
2024–25	Winter	162 excess winter deaths in Aberdeen City (IWMI 23%; 39% at 85+)	RSV vaccine extended to everyone 80+ from spring 2026
Nov 2025	Snow	Falls at emergency departments nearly doubled	n/a

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

DATE	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
Oct 2026	Flu starts earlier than any season on record; Scotland's Awaab's Law in force	n/a	This briefing

The recurrence nobody has noticed: Aberdeen's killing winters came in neutral or La Niña years. Its El Niño winters showed up early and from the east, as with Babet in October, and late, as ice. So the windows for action are October–November and then January–February, not December. The ENSO phases were checked against NOAA's ONI v6 table.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE

UNRESOLVED

- **Target the deprived estates** (Frontline, Economist, Food) versus **target age and frailty** (Public health). The NRS data supports the second for winter deaths. The estates still matter as the place where outreach finds older people, which is how this report uses them.
- **Restore a cold-snap payment from the Common Good Fund** (Economist: £25 per Winter Heating Payment recipient when Dyce averages at or below 0°C for seven days) versus **not feasible this winter** (verification). The Common Good income is already committed in the 2026/27 budget, and the council has no access to Social Security Scotland's recipient list without a data-sharing agreement. The Economist's point stands as a policy argument: Scotland's £62 Winter Heating Payment is flat, not triggered by cold, so households carry cold-snap risk themselves. UNVERIFIED
- **Stock food** (Food) versus **give cash** (Skeptic, Economist). Cash is the default. A small stock is held only for the days the A90 is shut and for households who cannot cook in a power cut.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED

BLIND SPOT

No lens found **Aberdeen-level drug-death, CO, or hypothermia counts**, so the year-round risks behind Northfield's high death rates are not quantified here. No lens confirmed **how Granitehill House is heated**, or whether any Northfield homes are still on electric storage heating, which decides who loses heat in a power cut. No lens looked at **care at home in snow**. Arwen showed home-care visits failing when roads closed, and the HSCP's contingency for that was not checked. Language data for these neighbourhoods was not found; Northfield Academy recorded 14 home languages in 2018.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

HOW TO READ THIS

METHOD

The panel is author-built. Eight simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people, and are not neighbourhood figures. Aberdeen City's population is about 227,000, so its impact region may extend beyond the city; it was inferred, not resolved. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*. Winter illness, cold, storms, and ice are carried here by National Records of Scotland data and the historical record, not by a published El Niño number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED

METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The request named “Northfield, Aberdeenshire”. OpenStreetMap places the suburb of Northfield in Aberdeen City (AB16); the Aberdeenshire matches are farm steadings. The briefing covers Northfield with Mastrick, Cummings Park, Heathryfold, and Middlefield. Climate Impact Lab impact region, as recorded here: the Aberdeen City council area, *inferred*. Where administrative data is used, the unit is named: Scotland (winter deaths by deprivation, benefits, vaccine uptake), Aberdeen City (excess winter deaths, fuel poverty, council budgets), NHS Grampian (falls), and SIMD 2020 data zones (Northfield-06 is the only decile-1 zone; Mastrick-04 and Heathryfold-02 are decile 2). None is Northfield alone.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality.
- **Expert panel.** Eight simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, philanthropist, and food supply chain analyst) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief. The Cupar, Fife briefing (11 October 2026) was the evidence pack for Scottish national programmes. Its claims were re-checked, not inherited. This run corrected its Pension Age Winter Heating Payment framing and could not find the Met Office quote it attributes to a 23 September 2026 blog. That quote is not used here; the 11 June 2026 Met Office blog is quoted instead.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias before it counted. Five lenses converged on the Priority Services Register, resting on Ofgem's and the Scottish Government's Arwen reviews of this region, so it held.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The lenses' emphasis on deprived postcodes did not survive the NRS deprivation analysis. Contradictions were kept. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort, each given a payer or marked unfunded, and the funding placements reconciled against them.

- **Verification.** Six separate verifier agents checked 16 recommendations and the five funding placements: health actions, financial actions (availability, payer, trigger, existing implementation), local operations, food (trigger frequency, forecast timing, channel capacity), CO and the contraindicated items, and the envelope (recipients, unit costs, duplication), which was then re-summed.
- **Who does what.** The RACI chart is built from the owners named in the verified actions, with one accountable party per action. It is a proposal: no organisation named in it has been contacted or has agreed to a role.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Could not be consulted. Two verifiers fetched it and got the empty client-side shell (“0 entries”), and no browser session was used. Earlier UK briefings recorded no UK entries for these hazards.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (vaccination, carbon monoxide and burning fuel indoors, and heating, damp, and mould) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total without the division being shown and labelled (Citizens Advice's £869 mean is shown as £5,069,233 ÷ 5,837). No local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in Northfield was interviewed. Several Aberdeen City Council committee papers and the warm-space pages would not load (Cloudflare or SSL errors, or 404), so some council details rest on search extracts. Whether the Persons at Risk Database upgrade finished, how Granitehill House is heated, and the 2026–27 warm-space hours are unconfirmed.

References · verified by Phase 5 unless marked. Met Office, El Niño declared, 11 Jun 2026 (verified) · NOAA ONI v6 (verified) · PHS respiratory surveillance, 8 Oct 2026 (verified) · CMO letter, RSV expansion 2026 (verified) · PHS RSV results, 2025 (verified) · Hayward et al. 2006 (verified) · Cochrane 2025, care-home staff vaccination (verified) · Jackson et al. 2006 (verified) · Wan et al. 2026 (verified) · Preval et al. 2017 (verified) · NRS winter mortality 2024/25 (verified) · NRS data tables (verified) · Pension Age Winter Heating Payment 2026 (verified) · Warm Home Discount eligibility (verified) · Winter Heating Payment £62 (verified) · Citizens Advice Aberdeen annual report 2024–25 (verified) · Fairer Aberdeen Fund 2026/27 (verified) · ACC cost-of-living budget 2026/27 (verified) · ACC cash-first pilot (verified) · SSEN-funded battery packs

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(verified) · Scarf Fuel Fund (verified) · Warm Home Prescription pilot, Aberdeen (verified) · ACC poverty demographic report (lens, not re-verified) · SSEN Priority Services Register (verified) · SSEN guaranteed standards 2026 (verified) · Ofgem Storm Arwen review (verified) · Scottish Government Storm Arwen review (verified) · ACC Storm Arwen update (verified) · ACC resilience annual report 2025 (verified) · ACC heat network connections (verified) · Aberdeen Heat & Power history (verified) · Scottish fire, smoke and CO alarm law (verified) · SFRS home fire safety visits (verified) · Devon & Somerset FRS, Storm Eunice CO (verified) · Awaab's Law, Scotland (verified) · UKHSA damp and mould guidance (verified) · Crossley & Zilio, Winter Fuel Payment (verified) · South Tyneside warm spaces evaluation (verified) · NHS Grampian falls, Jan 2023 (corrected) · NHS Grampian falls, Nov 2025 (verified) · Cummings Park Community Flat (verified) · Northfield Community Centre warm space (corrected) · North Locality Plan (lens, not re-verified) · Storm Babet supermarket deliveries (verified) · Beast from the East, empty shelves (verified) · CFINE parcels (corrected) · CFINE FareShare (verified) · Emergency food times, Aberdeen (verified) · Cash-First Programme final evaluation (verified) · FDF food inflation forecast (verified) · IGD food inflation forecast (verified) · ONS CPI, August 2026 (verified) · Storm Babet (lens, not re-verified) · Common Good budget 2026/27 (verified) · Bellwin thresholds (verified)

Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory

Generated 13 October 2026 for Northfield, Aberdeen. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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